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Universal Credit

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How to claim

You can apply for Universal Credit online.

You need to create an account to make a claim. You must complete your claim within 28 days of creating your account or you will have to start again. Your claim starts on the date you submit it in your account.

If you live with your partner, you will both need to create accounts. You'll link them together when you claim. You cannot claim by yourself.

If you cannot claim online, you can claim by phone through the Universal Credit helpline.

Check if you're better off on Universal Credit before you apply

If you already get benefits, you should work out if you'll be better off before you or your partner claim Universal Credit.

If you apply for Universal Credit those benefits might end and you will not be able to apply for them again, even if your application is not approved.

To check if you're better off, you can:

- use a benefits calculator (/benefits-calculators)
- contact the Citizens Advice Help to Claim service (https://www.citizensadvice.org.uk/about-us/contact-us/contact-us/help-to-claim/)
- ask a local benefits adviser (https://advicelocal.uk/find-an-adviser)

What you need to apply

To apply online you'll need:

- your bank, building society or credit union account details
- an email address
- access to a phone

If you do not have these, you can call the Universal Credit helpline or go to a jobcentre. You can also get support from the Citizens Advice Help to Claim service.

You'll also have to prove your identity. You'll need some identity documents for this, for example your:

- driving licence
- passport
- debit or credit card

- payslip or P60

To complete your claim you will need to provide information about:

- your housing (/housing-and-universal-credit), for example how much rent you pay
- your earnings, for example payslips
- your National Insurance number (/national-insurance/your-national-insurance-number), if you have one
- other benefits you get
- any disability or health condition that affects your work
- how much you pay for childcare if you want help with childcare costs
- your savings and any investments (/guidance/universal-credit-money-savings-and-investments), like shares or a property that you rent out

You might need an appointment with the Universal Credit team if:

- they need more information
- you cannot verify your identity online

You'll be told if this appointment will be in a jobcentre or on the phone.

You will have to go to a meeting to agree the activities in your claimant commitment (/universal-credit/your-claimant-commitment) before you can get your first payment.

Apply for Universal Credit online

Apply now

Help with your claim

There are 2 ways to get help with your Universal Credit claim. You can either call the Universal Credit helpline or use the Help to claim service.

Calls to the Universal Credit helpline are free.

Universal Credit helpline

> Universal Credit helpline
> Telephone: 0800 328 5644
> Welsh language: 0800 328 1744
> Relay UK (https://www.relayuk.bt.com) (if you cannot hear or speak on the phone): 18001 then 0800 328 5644
> British Sign Language (BSL) video relay service (https://connect.interpreterslive.co.uk/vrs?ilc=DWP) if you're on a computer - find out how to use the service on mobile or tablet (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oELNMfAvDxw)
> Monday to Friday, 8am to 6pm
> Find out about call charges (/call-charges)

Help to Claim

You can get free support from trained advisers to make a Universal Credit claim. They can help you with things like online applications or preparing for your first jobcentre appointment.

The Help to Claim service is provided by Citizens Advice and is confidential. They will not share your personal information unless you agree.

- Get Help to Claim if you live in England or Wales (https://www.citizensadvice.org.uk/helptoclaim)
- Get Help to Claim if you live in Scotland (https://www.cas.org.uk/helptoclaim)

If you've claimed Universal Credit before

Sign in to your account (/sign-in-universal-credit) to start a new claim.

If you could not make a claim

If you or your partner were delayed in making a claim through no fault of your own, you can backdate your claim by up to one month in certain circumstances.

You may be able to backdate your claim if:

- you have a disability (/definition-of-disability-under-equality-act-2010)
- you've had health problems that stopped you from claiming earlier
- the online service was not working and you claimed as soon as it was working again

- you were getting a different benefit before and you were not told it was going to stop
- you started a claim with a partner, but they did not complete their claim and now you're claiming as a single person

You can request to backdate your claim in your Universal Credit account (/sign-in-universal-credit), call the Universal Credit helpline or speak to your work coach.

You may be asked to provide evidence.

After you apply

You'll be given:

- a case manager who will check your claim and help you manage your Universal Credit
- a work coach if you need to look for work as part of your claimant commitment (/universal-credit/your-claimant-commitment)

If they need to contact you, it will be in the first few weeks after you apply. They'll send you journal messages in your online account. You'll usually get a text or email if you get a new message.

You need to sign in to your account (/sign-in-universal-credit) to check your journal and to-do list.

You'll never be asked to share personal information (such as bank details) in your journal, by phone, text or email. Find out how to avoid and report scams and phishing (/report-suspicious-emails-websites-phishing).

Your first payment

Check how and when you'll be paid (/universal-credit/how-youre-paid).

If you disagree with a decision

You can challenge a decision (/mandatory-reconsideration) about your claim. This is called asking for mandatory reconsideration.

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